

HASHKAMA WEEKLY

פרשת ראה
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By Reb Gemini חכמה ב-א תאמין?

Consider the following "Torah" thought, generated by Gemini: Did the AI get it right? Do you find it to be accurate? Or did the technology miss the boat?

Parshas Re'eh introduces the fascinating concept of basar ta'avah (Devarim 12:20), when a person explicitly states "Okhela basar," and the pasuk grants them full permission to consume it. During their time in the midbar, eating meat was strictly limited to shelamim, but preparing to enter Eretz Yisroel meant dealing with mundane reality, and perhaps preparing for the weekly cholent. The Ramban (Devarim 12:20) notes that the Torah specifically uses the raw language of ta'avah to demonstrate that this is a stark concession to physical desires. We are proud Litvaks; we do not naturally express ta'avah for absolutely anything other than a good pshetl in Rabbeinu Chaim, but the Torah recognizes that occasionally, a Yid just wants a large piece of brisket. However, Rashi (Devarim 12:20) points out that this permission comes with a subtle mussar about having means; one should only consume basar when they have the financial capability—or in modern terms, when they aren't paying for herring on a high-interest credit card. The Torah is telling us that indulging in the physical world is entirely permitted, but it requires boundaries, extreme self-awareness, and the fundamental understanding that your overwhelming desire for a post-davening kugel must not override your fiscal sanity. It is a profound lesson in taking the mundane and wrestling it into something resembling a true mentschlech existence.

This careful regulation of our appetite beautifully collides with a seemingly unrelated halacha later in the parsha, concerning ma'aser sheni (Devarim 14:23). We are commanded to take a tenth of our produce and eat it specifically in Yerushalayim. Why? The pasuk states explicitly, "Lema'an tilmad leyirah." Wait. How exactly does chewing on te'anim and rimonim in Yerushalayim teach a person yiras shamayim? Tosafos (Bava Basra 21a) explains that being constantly surrounded by kohanim in the absolute epicenter of kedusha naturally rubs off on you. Now connect this back to our basar ta'avah. The Torah knows that if you just eat brisket at home with zero context, you remain a physical being with dangerously high cholesterol. But by taking that exact same physical act of eating and transplanting it directly to Yerushalayim, sitting next to a talmid chacham, the chewing itself becomes a literal shiur in yiras shamayim. We actively elevate the ta'avah into pure avodah. This is our ultimate Litvish ideal: taking the dry, cold reality of physical existence and aggressively overthinking it until it becomes inherently holy. The Torah initially gives us basar ta'avah to acknowledge our basic nature, and then deliberately gives us ma'aser sheni to show us exactly how to weaponize that very same nature for immense ruchniyus.

The **practical takeaway** here completely transforms how we must approach our own mundane activities, especially around the shabbos table or the notoriously crowded shul kiddush. When you enthusiastically grab a massive piece of yapchik after a lengthy Mussaf, do not just blindly satisfy a ta'avah. Channel the rigorous lesson of ma'aser sheni. Sit next to someone who inspires you to be a better Yid, actively discuss a sharp vort from the Netziv (Devarim 14:23), and consciously elevate the cholesterol into pure kedusha. We must remember that every single slice of kugel has true spiritual potential. Make absolutely sure every physical act is deeply anchored in an environment that consistently teaches yiras shamayim, essentially turning our everyday eating into a vital kli for avodas Hashem.

News & Simchos!

This week's regular Kiddush features pastries, Kokosh cake, and a mercifully short shiur. Endure a few minutes of rigorous Torah analysis to officially justify your massive carbohydrate intake.

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Shabbus Zmanim

Chestnut Ridge, NY

מנחה pm --:-

הדלקה (Early/Late) 6:37/7:47 pm

מנחה - קבלת שבת pm --:-

שקיעה 8:05 pm

עלות השחר (16.1/72) 4:24/4:47 am

נץ החמה 5:59 am

7:00 am (14 Sergio) שחרית

ס"ז קריאת שמע 8:54/9:30 am

ס"ז תפילה 10:17/10:41 am

חצות היום 1:02 pm

מנחה גדולה (גרי"א) 1:37 pm

1:45 pm (14 Sergio) מנחה

מנחה קטנה (גרי"א) 5:08 pm

פלג המנחה (גרי"א) 6:36 pm

שקיעה 8:04 pm

צה"כ ר' משה (8.5/50) 8:49/8:54 pm

9:56 pm (52) מעריב

צה"כ (60/72) 9:04/9:16 pm



Next Week's Zmanim

Chestnut Ridge, NY

מנחה pm --:-

הדלקה (Early/Late) 6:30/7:38 pm

שקיעה 7:56 pm

7:00 am (14 Sergio) שחרית

שקיעה 7:55 pm

8:47 pm (52) מעריב

Parshah-ly Punny!

Riddle: Why was the navi sheker in Parshas Re'eh entirely unsuccessful when he attempted to solicit financial backing for his new idolatrous movement?

Answer: The astute baalebatim thoroughly analyzed his completely fabricated visions and quickly realized that his entire enterprise was strictly a non-prophet.

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משל ונמשל ב-Al תאמין? By Reb Gemini

Consider the following "Torah" thought, generated by Gemini: Did the AI get it right? Do you find it to be accurate? Or did the technology miss the boat?

Mashal: There is a famous mashal told about a profoundly intellectual Yid from Brisk who was appointed as the gabbai tzedakah for his local shtetl. One freezing winter morning, a destitute traveler knocked on the door of the shul, shivering violently and begging for a simple bowl of hot soup and a piece of bread. Instead of immediately running to the kitchen, the Brisker gabbai furrowed his brow and began a vigorous chakirah regarding the exact cheftza of the soup and the gavra of the beggar. He paced back and forth, muttering to himself, analyzing whether giving the soup constituted a maaseh kinyan of meshicha or if the beggar's empty stomach somehow acted as a chatzer to acquire the sustenance. He then loudly debated a machlokes in the Rishonim whether the chiyuv of hachnasas orchim demands specifically chicken soup or if a hearty fleishig cholent would fulfill the mitzvah b'dieved. By the time the gabbai reached a brilliant nafka minah regarding the temperature of the broth, the poor man had practically fainted from starvation on the bimah. The Rav of the shul walked in, witnessed this incredible display of analytical paralysis, grabbed a ladle, poured a massive bowl of soup, and handed it directly to the man. The Rav turned to his brilliant gabbai and sighed, noting that when a fellow Yid is standing in front of you starving, you do not build a chakirah in Hilchos Nedarim, you just build the man a sandwich.

Nimshal: This brilliant but misplaced intellectualizing is the exact nimshal for a critical halacha found in Parshas Re'eh regarding our obligation to the poor. The pasuk commands us, "Lo teametz es levavcha velo tikpotz es yadcha" (Devarim 15:7), warning us not to harden our hearts or shut our hands tight against our needy brother. The Torah then immediately follows with the positive commandment, "Pasoach tiftach es yadcha lo" (Devarim 15:8). We Litvaks possess a unique yetzer hara that frequently dresses up wearing a black hat and a frock, pretending to be a Rosh Yeshiva giving a shiur on the halachos of tzedakah just to keep our wallets closed. When a meshulach approaches, we suddenly become world-class private investigators. We demand to see his haskamah, we meticulously inspect the watermarks on the parchment, and we strongly consider calling the Gadol's personal shamash to verify the authenticity of the chasimah. The Kli Yakar (Devarim 15:8) highlights the double lashon of pasoach tiftach, explaining that you must open your hand repeatedly, even a hundred times if necessary, without subjecting the pauper to an exhausting interrogation. The Sefer HaChinuch (Mitzvah 477) famously teaches that the external physical act of consistently giving actually softens the internal heart. The Torah is demanding that we bypass our beloved, cold Litvish logic for just a moment; when you see a Yid in need, stop over-intellectualizing the chiyuv, silence your inner Brisker, and simply open your hand.

Practical Takeaway: The practical takeaway here directly addresses our collective behavior during chazaras hashatz on any given Sunday morning. We all know the highly choreographed shul dance: you are deeply engrossed in a difficult Ketzos HaChoshen (Choshen Mishpat 290:1), and suddenly a meshulach appears in your peripheral vision with a silver pushke. The immediate Litvish reflex is to avoid eye contact at all costs, perhaps aggressively swaying and pretending to be in the middle of a deeply emotional Shmoneh Esrei, even though the entire minyan knows you finished ten minutes ago. Do not do this. Do not start a furious internal sugya about whether you have already reached your exact ma'aser limit for the fiscal month. Prepare yourself before davening by filling your left pocket with a thick stack of singles or five-dollar bills. When the meshulach extends his hand, do not ask him for his entire lineage or a detailed business plan for how he intends to use the dollar. Smile warmly, drop the money in the pushke, and offer him a genuine brocha. By doing so, you are not merely giving tzedakah; you are actively breaking your own teva of stingy intellectualism. You transform an uncomfortable interruption into a profound moment of chesed, proving that while we may love to keep our minds exclusively in the Olam HaEmes, our hands and our wallets are completely engaged in the harsh realities of the Olam HaZeh.

GOOD SHABBUS!